Cambridge
O Level

Cambridge International Examinations
Cambridge Ordinary Level

ENGLISH LANGUAGE **1123/22**

Paper 2 Reading **October/November 2017**

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1 hour 45 minutes

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READ THESE INSTRUCTIONS FIRST

This Insert contains the two reading passages.

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Passage 1 – Fishing

1 Fishing is an ancient practice dating back at least 40 000 years, and studies of skeletal remains from this time show that people regularly ate freshwater fish. Shell heaps discovered by archaeologists prove that sea foods were also important for survival. During this time most people lived a nomadic life but, where there are early examples of permanent settlements, they are almost always associated with fishing as a major source of food.

2 Evidence exists that killing fish with spears was common in ancient times; a Greek historian of 2 000 years ago wrote an account of hunting for swordfish using harpoons; this account is fascinating even today. The Roman poet Oppian wrote of how fishermen struck the surface of the sea, encouraging frightened fish to jump straight from the sea into nets. Such was the importance of fishing to these ancient civilisations that their river and sea gods were always depicted carrying a three-pronged fishing spear. As early as the second century, fishermen were using the fly-fishing method, where artificial bait in bright colours attracted the fish to bite and made them easy captives.

3 Fish were an important part of the diet in North America, where river fish were caught using a hook suspended on a line. Line-fishing is a really cruel method by which a fish, attracted by the morsel of food on the end of the line, swallows the hook and then is pulled in on the line. In addition, some tribes used toxic plants to induce torpor in river fish to make them easy to catch.

4 Additionally, in other civilisations gill-nets suspended straight down into the water were used. These gill-nets were made of natural fibres, as archaeological evidence from the Middle East shows. Somewhat similar to gill-nets is trawling, a relatively modern method of fishing which involves pulling a net behind the boat. Fish are then hauled into the boat as it moves; however, this fishing method has been criticised by environmental groups because it catches other species of sea-life as well as the targeted species, and causes damage to the sea bed.

5 By the twentieth century, fishing methods had become so efficient that fish-processing vessels were developed. Once the fish are caught, these boats enable them to be cleaned, filleted, sorted and frozen, ready for sale before the boats land. Another improvement has been the invention of nets made of synthetic fibres, used because they are cheaper to manufacture, last longer and require less maintenance than traditional nets. Though still in its infancy, fish-farming, which involves breeding and raising fish commercially in tanks or enclosures, is another method of obtaining fish, the most commonly produced species worldwide being carp and salmon.

6 In modern times, a problem has been that fish stocks are significantly declining. People assume that the supply of fish in the world's rivers and oceans is limitless. Fairly recently, supplies of certain fish began to die out through overfishing because there were no rules about fishing them. The problem was made worse by the fact that some countries did not confine their fishing to their own shores, but also fished off the shore of other countries, causing serious depletion of fish stocks. The problem is worsened by the fact that often fishermen do not know the size of available fish stocks because they have not been properly informed.

7 One result of the decline in fish stocks is that, in an attempt to halt the decline, defined fishing seasons are allocated to individual groups of fishermen. There are some disadvantages in this system – for example, often fishermen are forced to set off in dangerous weather conditions because they have no choice. The introduction of fishing quotas, whereby commercial fishermen are limited in the number of fish they can take, is another way in which governments try to stop the decline in fish stocks. Moreover, authorities can pass laws about the fishing nets fishermen are permitted to use, by increasing the size of the mesh; this enables smaller fish to escape and boosts their numbers. Attempts are also made to educate fishermen about dwindling resources.

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8 Another problem associated with declining fish stocks is that sometimes the global struggle for them results in violence. It has been known for angry fishermen to attack fishermen from other countries, and some have been known to throw frozen fish at foreign coast-guard vessels. But at least all can agree that they have one common enemy: pirate fishermen. These pirates fish without licences, ignoring laws designed to preserve fish stocks. *55*

Passage 2 – Michael

1 Michael walked home from school, a mad decision in the heat, even at this time of day. But when he had left the building, he could see that the buses were stranded in the city traffic, their wheels motionless on the softening tarmac, so he set off on foot. The houses seemed to exude heat from their bricks, making the streets into a sweltering labyrinth through which he must toil. It was the last day of term, the start of the long summer holidays. For six whole weeks there would be no more marking, no more teaching classes, and above all no more rushing out in the mornings. He had made it to the end of another school year. His relief was so enormous that it manifested itself physically. He felt happy, he felt unburdened, and he had a dizzy sensation in his head.

2 He paused under the trees that fringed the park and surveyed the damage caused by this never-ending heatwave. The grass was a scorched brown, and the bare earth was showing through it; the park was no longer the undulating green he had always loved. He recalled the park in previous summers as a space of different shades of green. And now the normally beautiful flowerbeds were empty and arid.

3 He set off on the most direct route, straight across the burnt out grass. Sweat broke out along his hairline and down his spine. He swatted a bead of moisture from his upper lip and switched his bulging briefcase to the other hand. There was a queue at the water stand-pipe at the end of his street. Several of his neighbours meandered listlessly across the pavement and onto the road, carrying empty containers. Some of them chatted to each other and one or two waved to him as he passed.

4 He unlatched the gate and swung it open. He loved his house, and the fact that he and his wife had bought it with their own money – or their own money along with a large bank loan – never ceased to amaze him. He didn't have to leave his home for six whole weeks. Joy surged involuntarily through him as he remembered that it contained the two people most precious to him in the world. He unlocked the door, flung his bag to the floor and picked his way through the flotsam of bricks, miniature cars and pieces of jigsaw puzzles on the hall floor. In the living room his nine-year-old son kissed him and then returned to reclining on the sofa with his eyes fixed on the television, where grinning cartoon characters danced across the screen. The debris of more assorted toys covered the floor. 'Mum's studying,' his son told Michael. 'She's not to be disturbed unless it's a matter of life and death.'

5 At the top of the stairs Michael found his way blocked by the ladder that led up to the attic. He had bought the ladder because he had always wanted a playroom in an attic when he had been a boy, and so he had wanted this for his own son, this place of refuge. Never had he anticipated it being commandeered by his wife, of all people. Now the attic was not how he had envisaged it at all. Instead of a train set, there was a paper-strewn desk; instead of building bricks, there were shelves of books. There were no collections of shells or leaves or any of those things children covet, just notebooks and folders.

6 Michael had been thinking for a long time of a way to tell his wife that he was happy to support her in her newly found passion for learning, her apparent desire to achieve what had, for a variety of reasons, been beyond her reach before their marriage. But communication with her these days was almost impossible. There was a new look of hostility in her eyes. She had not even told him that she had enrolled for college classes. As Michael climbed the ladder into the attic, his wife gradually appeared to him from the feet up – toes, ankles, legs, her back curved over the table, her arms, her hand clutching a pen. 'Oh Michael,' she said, without turning round. 'I thought I heard you come in.'

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